LEADERSHIP TRANSITIONS IN UNIVERSITIES

Arriving, Surviving and Thriving at the Top

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ROUTLEDGE

8 Working on the agenda

Do strategy and planning really matter?

If I'm honest with you, I'm a strategy sceptic.

Introduction

The foregoing quote was expressed in somewhat hushed tones, as if it were something you should not admit to as a head of university (HoU). Did I hear you correctly? You are a strategic leader, and *you* are sceptical about strategy? It was an interesting comment, made amid an HoU's second year in office and towards the end of an extensive process of engagement and consultation to update the strategic plan. After further discussion about the process and its outcomes, more people converted to the sceptic movement. Why should this be?

This chapter explores the key transition issues facing an incoming or established HoU as they grapple with how to 'be strategic' and 'develop a strategy' as a leader rather than a member of the senior team. All eyes are on you. Adding to the pressure is increasing external uncertainty and the realisation that the outcomes could either impact badly on the highly successful university you have inherited or accelerate the decline of a precariously positioned institution. In today's world of higher education (HE), we might also ask, has the strategy and planning process become one of those symbolic rites of passage, a process largely detached from the world inhabited by most staff in universities? Or, in a world of increasing uncertainty and complexity, are these processes even more important? Do they really matter?

We start by exploring the case for and against *strategy* and *planning*. We then return to the different transition contexts that you may be facing and consider some of the ways that you might respond.

First, let's look to the sceptics. What are they saying? And how should we respond if they are actually right?

The sceptics' case

Scepticism about strategy and planning seems to be on the rise. One of our interviewees commented as follows:

> *I was talking to my senior team just on Monday, saying, you know, I'm not sure that the idea of long-term planning or short-term planning – you know*

> *5 years or 20 years, those seem to be what most institutions are doing now. I'm not sure that that is actually what we should be doing. I think a vision statement for the long-term direction of an institution is vital, but I'm not sure we can do much more than that, given the level of uncertainty.*

They are not alone. Several HE commentators appear to agree. John Ross, in the *Times Higher* in 2019,[1] explored the processes and practices of strategy and planning in the UK and Australia. Much of his evidence supports the sceptics' case. One source argues that

> *The primary driver of most strategic plans is the leadership's craving for status. And the plans' defining feature – like that of the institutions whose destinies they supposedly chart – is their sameness – both in terms of their common focus on status and their hideous propensity to [employ] the most execrable prose known to humanity. We've had years of strategic planning, which becomes a bit of an industry in itself, and what is there to show for it? Essentially, what we've got are universities that are pretty much the same.*

In *Does My Institution Need a Strategic Plan?*, Alex Usher[2] from Canada also makes some cogent arguments, and he concludes as follows:

> *After a decade of doing this job, I have come to the conclusion that while most institutions do not spend enough time planning, too many of those that do issue plans are under the mistaken impression that these plans are in any way strategic.*

He asks if all planning is necessarily strategic:

> *Well no. Strategic planning is fundamentally about change. If an institution does not intend to make significant changes, then it probably does not need a strategic plan. It may still need some kind of plan by which senior management can guide and evaluate the work of senior staff, but such a plan is not properly 'strategic'. An awful lot of institutional plans out there, to my mind, come under this definition. (Which is* ***fine****. Institutions don't always need to change. Sometimes they need to consolidate. The trick is knowing whether you need to change or consolidate at the outset of the process).*
>
> (our emphasis, in boldface)

One of our interviewees described planning as neither systematic or strategic:

> *Planning was haphazard; there was no formal planning round. I don't know how they did it. I really genuinely don't know how they did it. They had something that kind of happened around the edges and because the university was well off, I think they could cope.*

Usher adds further reflections in *Strategic Planning for Ambiguous Organisations*,[3] in which he postulates two broad types of plans:

- *the laundry-list strategic plan – just a whole bunch of stuff that keeps various constituencies happy. These tend to be heavy on tactics and goals but weak on overarching strategy*.
- *the ultra-vague strategic plan – mission/vision statements which are motherhood statements, and a list of goals that either directly or indirectly are about obtaining more resources for the institution (because the one thing that unites every agenda at a university is the belief that achieving each of them would be a lot easier if there were more dollars available)*.

A third, highly experienced HE author, from the US, Peter Eckel, also offers evidence to support the sceptics' case:[4]

> *All institutions have strategic plans; yet, few have a strong consensus that they are meaningful and consequential in that they lead to real impact. Typical strategic plans focus on a set timeframe, such as five years; some are bold enough for 10-year efforts. They are crafted by a committee after extensive, if not exhaustive, input from a variety of stakeholders; although many examples exist of the lone president writing the plan over a weekend. And in the end, some become guiding documents that provide a roadmap for the future, but too many do not. The rate of return of all of that effort is gravely disappointing. Institutions invest a lot of hours in planning that they cannot recapture*.

Beyond HE, sceptics also exist. David Maister, former Harvard Business School consultant who focused on professional service firms, concluded as follows in *Strategy and the Fat Smoker*:[5]

> *Much of what professional firms do in the name of strategic planning is a complete waste of time, no more effective than individuals making New Year's resolutions. The reasons are the same in both situations. Personally, and professionally, we already know what we should do: lose weight, give up smoking, exercise more. In business, strategic plans are also stuffed with familiar goals: build client relationships, act like team players, provide fulfilling, motivating careers. We want the benefits of these things. We know what to do, we know why we should do it and we know how to do it*.
>
> *The primary reason we do not work at areas in which we know we need to improve is that the rewards (and pleasure) are in the future; the disruption, discomfort and discipline needed to get there are immediate. To reach our goals, we must first change our lifestyle, our daily habits, now*.

Another Canadian source, in *The Big Lies of Strategy*,[6] points to the compromises often made:

> *The practices involved in strategic planning leave me cold – and the reason is, the typical strategic plan isn't terribly useful. Most strategic plans have three sections. The first is some lofty vision or mission statement, and the middle section tends to be a list of initiatives: 'Here are a bunch of things we're going to do'. Sometimes that's good, because it is action-oriented, but if you look at most strategic plans – at least the ones I've seen – you can almost see how the list of initiatives came to be. There is a little bit in there for marketing and a little bit for manufacturing and a little bit for finance; it is basically a list of compromises that were made by a bunch of people sitting around a table saying, 'We want to do this', and 'We want to do that'. Then lastly, there are the financials, which I often refer to as 'a budget written in prose'. I don't find any of this very helpful in terms of laying out the key choices that a firm needs to make.*

A failure to make clear choices was also a theme picked up by Vermeulen in *Many Strategies Fail Because They're Not Actually Strategies*:[7]

> *Many strategy execution processes fail because the firm does not have something worth executing. One major reason for the lack of action is that new 'strategies' are often not strategies at all. A real strategy involves a clear set of choices that define what the firm is going to do and what it's not going to do. Many strategies fail to get implemented, despite the ample efforts of hard-working people, because they do not represent a set of clear choices.*

What these sources tell us is that the notions of strategy and strategic planning as currently defined are being challenged as no longer 'fit for purpose'. The sceptics are questioning current ways of working and the historical and prevailing orthodoxies of strategic planning. Five-year plans that stay unchanged and untouched between these episodic moments; airy statements of vision, mission and values; six key priorities; and other variants of strategic plans are under increasing scrutiny, although they still dominate the landscape.

However, an increasing number of universities are taking a different approach. Horizons are being extended to look to (at least) a ten-year horizon from 2020 to 2030 or extended longer, where some stretch from 2020 to 2040 and beyond. Others are seeking to articulate longer-term strategic narratives and statements of ambition. Gradually evolving is a move from lots of work to create a 'launch document' towards a process that also grapples with and focuses on strategy implementation, gaining 'lift-off' – a topic to which we return in Chapter 9. A more integrated approach is emerging. Others are placing more focus on the culture of

the organisation: being 'values led'. The work of the Magna Charta Observatory, the Living Values project,[8] is an interesting example of this movement, and other universities are creating strategies that have explicit linkages to global agendas, such as the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

These shifts are indeed food for thought. But how do you avoid losing the best of the old while introducing new ways that are a better fit for the future?

The case for strategy and planning: *why these might really matter*

Many of the sceptics are also proponents of the importance of strategy (done differently) and in some cases, also planning. In 'What is the point of a strategic plan?' Ross of the *Times Higher*[9] cites the case of David Lloyd, president of the University of South Australia (UniSA), when Lloyd transitioned into the top job in 2013:

> *He resisted marking his arrival with some bold new statement of strategic direction, quietly developed in the confines of the chancellery and polished to a glossy sheen by the marketing unit. Instead, Lloyd unleashed generational change befitting a 38-year-old vice-chancellor. He enlisted not only the university community but also its global extended family to help the University of South Australia hone its mission. Unijam made use of IBM technology to inject thousands of people into round-the-clock online conversations structured around themes, with registered participants logging in whenever they liked to gatecrash existing discussions or start new ones. The university says nearly 8000 people from 56 countries registered for the 38-hour event, posting almost 18,000 comments across more than 1300 conversation 'threads', overseen by IBM-trained umpires.*
>
> *Lloyd says that far from making UniSA a carbon copy of neighbouring institutions, its strategic plan – and the crowdsourced input – helped entrench its point of distinction as 'Australia's university of enterprise'.*
>
> *'Without a strategy, you don't get that end point', he says.*
>
> *If we hadn't done it, we would have been like every other university. We'd be aspiring to have great research, but the research would be in pockets where you've got individual superstars, not clusters* [on which] *you can build in scale and focus.*

Eckel also makes the 'pro-case' in his book on shared governance:[10]

> *Many institutions, including highly innovative ones, do have a strategy, it just isn't reflected in their planning documents.*

His central question is,

> *What would happen if HEIs focused on strategy rather than planning?*

Eckel's answer (like others') is that strategy is about making choices, clarifying how to compete and on what basis. Strategy also clarifies direction and why the university has chosen a particular direction.

Alex Usher[11] is more of a fan of planning and reminds us that

> *Planning is not the same thing as plans. Planning is the systematic scanning of the horizon for possible change/advantage/disadvantage and discussion/gaming of options in various circumstances. Plans are specific sequences of tasks meant to get an organization from point A to point B. Dwight Eisenhower is reputed to have said that 'plans are worthless, but planning is everything'. Why? Because reality is brittle. Plans can fall apart in the face of small changes in environment. Or, to quote Mike Tyson, 'Everyone has a plan until they get a punch in the mouth'.*

Maister, in *Strategy and the Fat Smoker*,[12] makes the case for strategy by using a different metaphor:

> *'Strategy is the diet, not the goal'. Debating which goals to pursue (whether you wish to choose losing weight, giving up smoking, ceasing to drink or starting to exercise) is a nonsensical process if you lack the discipline to stick with the (different) diet and exercise programs that each of these requires. The only meaningful debate is which diet you are really ready to get on.*
>
> *Giving up smoking may be better for you (or a better competitive strategy), but if you're not willing to make the changes that that specific goal requires, its relative importance is irrelevant. It's the same in business. Discussing 'strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats' (to take only the oldest and most familiar of the strategic planning exercises) is fun, but gets nowhere near the real questions. Improving the quality of the analysis is not where the problem lies. The necessary outcome of strategic planning is not analytical insight but resolve. The essential questions of strategy are these: Which of our habits are we really prepared to change, permanently and forever? Which lifestyle changes are we really prepared to make? What issues are we really ready to tackle?*

Adding some new voices, Reeves, Sinha and Haanaes in *Your Strategy Needs a Strategy*,[13] argue that in today's environment, strategy needs to be a much more nuanced process. Picking the right approach from their 'strategy palette' is crucial, as is the ability to change focus when required. They propose five alternative approaches to strategy, based on three key elements: how *predictable* is the environment, how *malleable* is it (i.e. the extent to which you believe you can change the environment) and how *harsh* is it? If you are in a state of crisis, you must get recovery sorted while also thinking about which of the other four approaches you will subsequently adopt.

The following are the four approaches that these authors identify:

1 *The classical strategy*: Classical strategising is a three-part process that consists of analysis, construction of a plan and rigorous execution. The analysis is focused on the attractiveness of a market, the basis of competition and a firm's competitiveness. The resulting plan forecasts those factors, articulates the targeted position and maps the steps to achieve it. Classical firms implement their plan exactly.
2 *The visionary strategy*: Rare, but incredibly effective, a visionary approach empowers a firm to create or recreate an industry with some degree of predictability by seeing an opportunity and pursuing it single-mindedly. Being first confers the advantage of superior size that comes with being ahead of rivals and allows a firm to set industry standards, influence customer preferences, develop a superior cost position, and determine the direction for an entire market.
3 *The adaptive strategy*: Strategising in the adaptive context requires a process of watching and responding to changes in the environment by capturing change signals and managing a portfolio of experiments. Adaptive firms continuously vary the way they do business by trying many novel approaches and then scaling up and exploiting the most promising before repeating the cycle. Successful adaptive firms outperform rivals by iterating more rapidly and effectively than their competitors.
4 *The shaping strategy*: Shaping firms engage other stakeholders to create a shared vision at the right point in time, to build a platform through which they influence and orchestrate collaboration, and, finally, to evolve the platform and ecosystem by scaling it and keeping it flexible. Therefore, the way to win is through co-development of the market and industry by multiple players. As with the adaptive approach, the shaping strategy eventually emerges from continuous iteration of three elements: repeated engagement, orchestration, and evolution of the ecosystem.

Reeves and fellow authors argue that to be successful, strategy needs to be matched to context. The challenge is that in the multiplicity of 'industry sectors' within universities, contexts vary considerably. Some areas of the university are operating in a 'classical world', whereas others could explore an adaptive, visionary or shaping approach to strategy.

Rather than a singular approach, this particular framework might work better by thinking of your strategy as a portfolio where the approach required is different in different areas of the university. The authors make the same point for an entire organisation by emphasising the need for an ambidextrous approach to the strategy process. Being clear about vision and strategic direction might be most important in a university.

The value of a meaningful vision, often linked to the origins of the university, was emphasised several times by our interviewees. Take the following example:

> *I think the point about the vision is, it gives you a bit of a framework within which you want to keep those decisions. So that's not to say you might not oscillate quite a bit within and there might not be quite a bit of turbulence, but you are still trying to go in a particular direction. And that vision, I think, comes from one of a number of things. I think many of us play back to the origins of an institution. What were the fundamentals about this place that led to its creation?*

Having considered both sides of the debate about whether strategy and planning matter, we return to the realities of how to address different strategy conditions as you come to understand your new context and the actions that you need to take.

Responding to different strategy contexts

The context that you inherit will influence the timing, importance and urgency that you give to the strategy development process. Typically, upon arrival, you may encounter one of these six situations:

- *A recently drafted* and beautifully presented strategic plan that sets out an agenda for action over the next five years; you may – or more likely may not – thank your predecessor for this
- *A formal strategic plan* (often of the five-year duration) that has a short shelf life to its end date, typically 12–18 months
- A series of largely **operational documents** that are disconnected from each other, focused on an annual planning and budgeting process
- *A strategic narrative or strategic vision* with a long timeline (e.g. to 2030 or beyond), that is referenced but that does not seem to be influencing behaviours or decisions
- A formal strategic plan which has passed its end date (typically by one to two years) – in theory, the **'no plan' situation**
- *An interim strategic transition plan*, which the departing leader has created following a recent review of an existing plan (e.g. in the past six to 12 months) and that has an end point in one to two years' time

Your approach will also be influenced by the performance of the university (financially and academically) and the style and level of expectations of your governing body.

Any of these situations will influence the timeline on the basis of which you decide to conduct any strategy review, how sceptical you may be about the plan or process of arriving at it and what the outcome(s) might be. How can you ensure that your preferred approach makes the process an important matter?

Be aware of the following temptations:

- *First is the temptation to 'rise to the bait'* – to respond to the challenge from a frustrated chair/chancellor who encourages you to quickly decide on and publish 'your vision', typically far too soon.

- The second temptation is to 'let a thousand flowers bloom'. In this situation, the leader sets out on an extensive period of uncoordinated consultation. Many ideas may be proposed, or, depending on your predecessor's legacy in this area, you may encounter limited engagement or limited willingness to propose ideas.
- A third common temptation is for you to undertake an extensive engagement exercise. This may not be an inappropriate thing to do; however, when it becomes a process with no end in sight or a process with no obvious synthesis of findings, this 'lone leader distraction' approach can conclude with a 'vision' that no one disagrees with but rarely inspires action.
- *A fourth temptation is to outsource the process* – either to internal consultants, by delegating to your deputy or director of strategy (if you have one), or to external consultants. In these situations, you distance yourself from the exercise.
- Finally, you might be tempted to believe that you need to answer all the questions about the university's future, early on. Tempting as engaging with these expectations may be, we caution against providing immediate answers. Rather, consider the key questions to which you need to find answers collectively as you gradually navigate through and shape your future together.

Whatever the context, your role as HoU in this area is key. Learning fast might be required, as one interviewee discovered:

> *I did have to learn quite quickly, but my background is numbers, so I have always been quite quick on the uptake with numbers and a lot of it isn't actually the accounting detail. It is the big picture stuff, so it's being able rapidly to gain an understanding of a large complex set of numbers and make some reasonable assumptions that you can then use as the basis, taking advice from the finance director (FD) as needed, but ultimately, you are taking the plan and the budget to the board for approval, so you have got to be able to defend it and understand it in enough detail, that you don't have to keep deferring to the FD.*

Another emphasised the importance of taking an active role in engaging with staff:

> *I would say, when I've been creating a strategy, and launching it, the shift to internal, for me, has gone 10% external to 90% internal to really drive that through and that was the same for the first plan period and this one . . . because of the very engaged approach that I take. I know many people don't choose to go down that way and it's more of a dusting off for the board's approval, job done. I've seen that backfire on one or two occasions*

> *recently – where you haven't re-engaged staff and driven that engagement through yourself. I think it is really important to lead from the front and be visible. I think if you are not visible at those core times of transition in strategy, I think that is problematic and some people have come unstuck by not doing that.*

Board engagement was critical:

> *There was a journey that took 12 months of engagement with the board to actually shape the new vision which was different and was very much based on raising our profile and building those connections and partnerships, which the board signed up to and were quite excited by. . . . It was the right time and the right evidence points for our approach and also the right time to grow and a clear case was made for the investment.*

In the context of the COVID-19 pandemic and heightened levels of uncertainty, the balancing of which approach to adopt became even more challenging. We return to this in Chapter 10.

Making it matter: *from answers to questions*

You might be tempted to present a concise ten-point plan which, if followed to the letter, will address the concerns of the sceptics and offer you guaranteed success with your strategy and planning processes. Yet the last thing you need is a recipe book solution when you might not yet have decided whether you want a three-course meal or when you have no idea what ingredients you have to work with. Nonetheless, you have to make a start and make it matter.

First, create headspace and time to address your (we hope) healthy level of scepticism. You will need to decide what type of strategy is necessary and what role you will adopt in the process. As with so many aspects of being an HoU, the role you need to play is different from what you have played in previous positions. Even if you were central to developing a strategy elsewhere or before, this is different, and what makes it so is your responsibility for engaging with the board. They will ultimately decide to invest in the strategy and assess whether you have delivered. Setting the scene is therefore vital for the exercise – clarifying the process, timeline and key points of engagement with the board. You will need to judge the board's level of ambition and attitude to risk and their view of available resources. These are important and time-consuming activities and cannot be delegated to others, particularly in the early days.

A second part of your role is as architect of the exercise. This is not about the technical aspects, which can and should be delegated to your provost/DVC and head/director of strategy (if such roles exist). It's more about style of approach and the boundaries you set (explicitly or implicitly) around the exercise. You might

intentionally or inadvertently send a signal that one or more issues are 'undiscussable', and if you are not careful, these could become the significant 'elephant in the room' issues that everyone feels should be explored but have been perceived as off limits.

In the strategy development (or review) phase, it is helpful to ask more questions of yourself and others rather than offering answers or solutions too early. Two frameworks may be useful. The first is focused on 'looking back' – what can you learn from your existing strategy and plan? The second is about 'looking forwards' – including some (apparently) obvious questions about the concept, principles and process of developing a new strategy.

How strategic is your plan?

The first framework gives a chance to take stock of the existing strategy and plan – formal or informal – that you have inherited. What insights can you gain from this process? The following framework is based on nine dimensions:

1 *Strategic thinking* – anticipating 'there', involving analysis and horizon scanning
2 *Strategic positioning* – being 'there', involving making choices
3 *Strategic change management* – getting to 'there', involving implementation
4 *Strategic performance measurement* – measuring 'there', involving metrics and key performance indicators
5 *Strategic communication and engagement* – communicating (and integrating) 'there', involving key messages
6 *Strategic team working* – focused energy towards getting 'there', involving creating ownership and mutual accountability with the senior leadership team
7 *Strategic disinvestment* – clearing the way to get to 'there', involving what to reduce or not to do
8 *Strategic innovation* – finding new ways to get to 'there', involving identifying areas for experimentation to test novel ideas
9 *Strategic emergence and engagement* – getting the appropriate balance of explicit and emergent strategies, involving both top-down and bottom-up engagement

A more extensive version can be provided upon request (email tkennie@ranmore.co.uk). After considering these dimensions yourself, we encourage you to invite members of your senior leadership team to consider the dimensions so that you can compare perspectives about your current baseline position.

Strategy challenge

The second framework (part of which is outlined below) provides further questions.

Experiences, Concepts and Language:

1 What have you learned from your prior experiences of strategy development and delivery? What do you collectively mean by 'having a strategy'?

The Context & Commitment:

2 How explicitly have you defined and recognised your collective *appetite for risk and level of ambition for the period of the strategy?*

Reflections on Your Collective Thinking So Far:

3 What are your collective views about your shared *statement of purpose (or mission), shared ambition (or vision) and values?*

Perspectives on distinctiveness, assumptions and bias:

4 Have you adequately articulated *your existing distinctiveness and your distinctive ambition?*
5 What *assumptions* have you made (implicitly or explicitly) so far? Are any of these overly limiting? Are these tested? Do any require further challenge?
6 Are any of the potential *strategy bias factors* worthy of further consideration?

Clear choices:

7 If your strategy as you are currently imagining it was implemented and you were looking back on progress at the end of the timeline, how different would the university be from today? *What choices will you need to make to deliver these outcomes?*

Confidence and next steps:

8 *How confident are you* about your team's collective commitment to delivery of your strategy?
9 Are you clear about the *phasing and pacing of the delivery process?*

Asking some of these 'apparently basic questions' provides a chance for foundational issues to be explored early on, before you become too involved in the mechanics of the process. Again, further details are available upon request (email tkennie@ranmore.co.uk).

Flexible futures and focus: *scenario thinking*

The process of scenario thinking in its many forms is not new. Developed originally by the company Shell, it has become widely used in many sectors over the

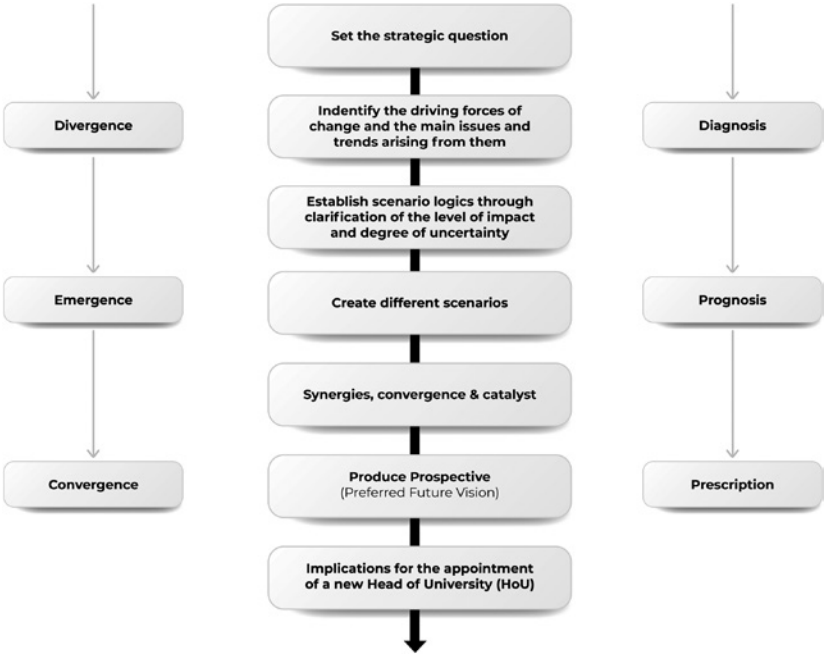

Figure 8.1 The Imagineering scenario-thinking process

past 40 years or longer. It's a technique with many merits, but it is often viewed as a nice thing to do rather than as an invaluable part of the strategy development and testing process. As we explore in Chapter 10, when you're leading in a crisis, it becomes an essential tool. What's different in a crisis, in particular, is that the process is not used as an episodic exercise (undertaken every five years or so), but as a more frequent exercise aimed at addressing key uncertainties.

Professor John Ratcliffe, who at the time ran the Futures Academy at the Technological University of Dublin, developed his 'Imagineering' methodology on the basis of scenario thinking in a project titled University Futures: The Direction, Shape and Provision of Higher Education in the University of the Future.[14] The framework is outlined in Figure 8.1.

The first step is to define the strategic question that you wish to examine. On the basis of this, the next step involves some structured horizon scanning around the issue you wish to explore. For example, if the issue was to understand the longer-term implications of the COVID-19 pandemic on global higher education, the approach (based on an Australian perspective) used by Croucher and Locke[15] illustrates one application. Using a standard PESTEL (political, economic, social, technological, environmental and legal analysis), the researchers identified nine key potential uncertainties and trends:

1 Diminishing student preference for travel to undertake international education
2 Growing student acceptance of, and preference for, online study
3 Diminishing attractiveness of certain degrees and programmes
4 Diminishing capacity for governments to invest in higher education and research
5 Greater government and public reliance on areas of expertise deemed relevant to economic and social recovery
6 Uncertain prospects for university-delivered transnational education
7 Fewer students travelling internationally for doctoral study
8 Uncertain future opportunities for research collaboration
9 Less philanthropy and external research funding not from governments

Other authors have also been seeking to capture the medium- to longer-term uncertainties and scenarios for higher education, from a US perspective, such as Staley (2020)[16] 'Alternative Universities' and Alexander (2019)[17] 'Academia Futures'. Their works were created before the COVID-19 pandemic. Nonetheless, they are worth considering. Alexander, in particular, has been providing a continuing update and synthesis of developments and trends through his creative commons licensed Future Trends in Technology and Education (FTTE).[18]

The next phase involves creating a series of scenario narratives by identifying and crafting the most significant uncertainties into a view of different futures. As an example of one such framing, the following scenarios were crafted in mid 2020 to inform discussions, in a number of UK universities, on the potential global futures for higher education (Figure 8.2).

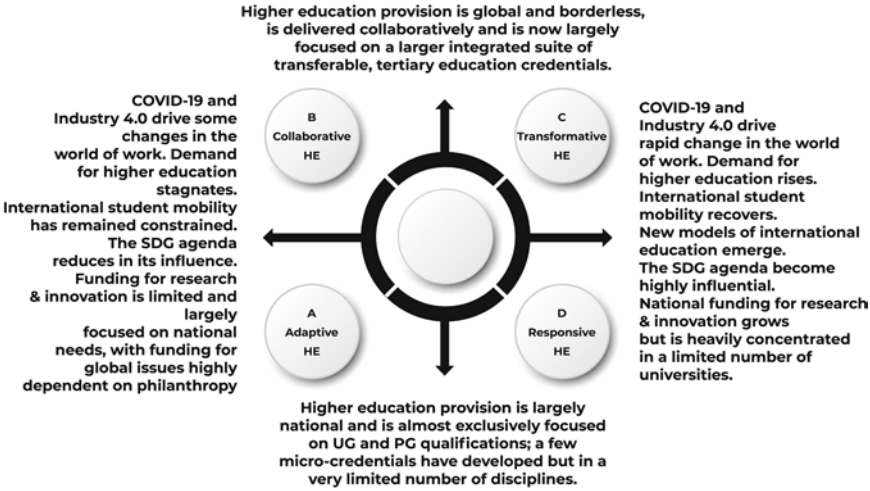

Figure 8.2 Global scenarios for higher education. SDG – Sustainable Development Goals

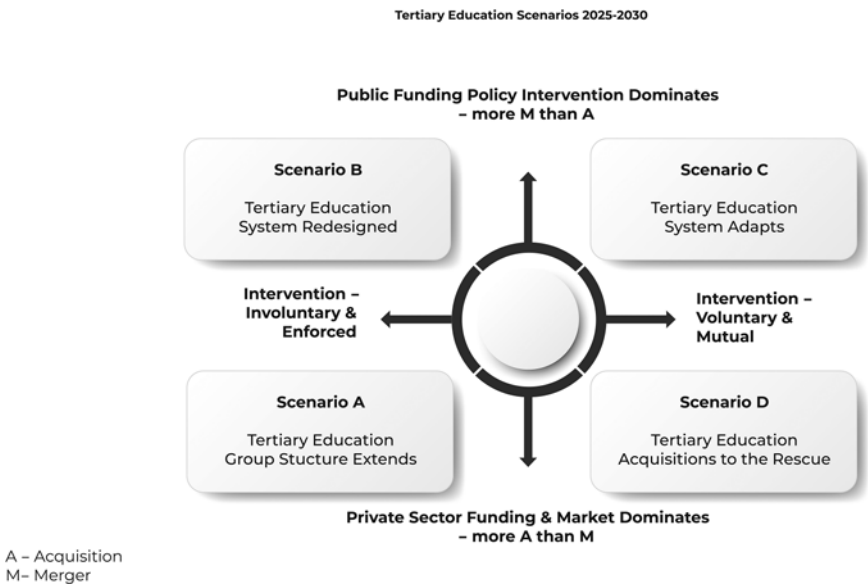

Figure 8.3 Future scenarios for a tertiary education system in the UK

The scenarios offer an opportunity for leaders to explore what and how higher education might respond to these alternative futures. The scenarios then allow you to consider the potential implications for current strategic agendas. Some stress testing can also be undertaken to assess the risks and opportunities that arise for each picture of the future.

Scenarios may also be used to explore more-specific questions. For example, what might be the different futures associated with parts of a new ecosystem? What might a 'dual sector' tertiary education system look like in the UK? Figure 8.3 offers a range of ways in which the scenarios might unfold, and it enables further consideration of how government intervention might be provided or how private sector investment might flow towards higher and further education.

These scenarios point towards collaboration (whether it is voluntary and mutual or involuntary and imposed). What will the level of mergers or acquisitions be, and will these grow over the next decade? Learning from the lessons of the past is key (see Curaj et al. 2015[19] and Kernohan 2020[20]). These authors offer some wise words about the dangers of forced mergers – and the value of a different approach to collaboration – through alliances.

Hillman[21] also asked, 'Are we on the cusp of a wave of university mergers?' on the basis of evidence that emerged in May 2020. Citing the outcomes of an earlier study, he comments that[22]

> *The one factor, however, that comes out above all others, in determining the success of merger discussions is the degree to which there are strong negative*

> *push factors forcing the merger. Such circumstances appear to be an incentive to overcome all other barriers. On the other hand, where there are no significant push factors to merger, a wide range of issues can be potentially deal-breaking.*

Hillman concludes that despite the financial challenges ahead, 'There is no impending push, almost anything else can be a deal breaker'. Time will tell whether over the next five to ten years we will see more coordinated collaboration, leading to more-formal structural change.

The techniques of scenario thinking are needed also for much closer short-term planning; not a 10- to 20-year horizon but a six- to eight-month horizon. As an example of this, Alex Usher, in late March 2020, provided a useful framing of short-term scenarios to help think about the future for student entry into Canadian universities in the autumn of 2020:[23]

> *Scenario planning might sound too abstract to be a priority in the middle of a crisis, but hear me out. We're in unknown territory for an unknown amount of time, and so the best thing to do is to look at a range of possible outcomes, work backwards from those to see which kinds of activities might have the most salience over the greatest number of outcomes, and focus on those.*
>
> *The main axis for scenario planning is time: a September re-open for face-to-face instruction is massively different than a January re-open (and to be honest I'm not sure we can rule out a Spring 2021 date). But there are a couple of other areas that need to be taken into account, as well. One is regulatory/fiscal change. Much will depend on what health authorities and governments might allow as the virus recedes. Will institutions be allowed to maintain courses for more than 50 students? Will cafeterias be allowed to re-open? What about residences? If so, under what conditions? There are a range of possibilities here for which institutions need to plan.*

The key thing is for every institution to get a sense of the main scenarios and ask themselves the following three questions:

1. What actions can we take that would do the most to minimise harm across all scenarios?
2. Across the range of scenarios, what actions give us the greatest advantage across the greatest number of scenarios?
3. Given the answers to questions 1 and 2, you must ask, are there areas where responses to short-term scenarios materially affect answers to longer-term scenarios in a significant way?

Conclusion

> *I'm really not a sceptic. . . . It's all about the quality of what you do, the pride you have in the work you do, the pride you have in the university, and that needs a clear strategic view. . . . Actually, that has been a significant part of my work since day 1. Maybe not refreshing the strategy or re-creating it, but re-aligning the way we*

> *are doing it and explaining it. . . . I can't believe that you can do this work without a strategic view of what you are doing. It would just be drifting. I think universities will ultimately move on to be different from one another. We need to know about where the strengths are and where we sit in the sector, so [a strategic view] is quite important to me.*

Developing a whole-university strategy is an issue that you will have to address at least once and probably several times during your period as HoU. Your role in this process differs from roles that you have played before and will place new demands on you. When done well and when linked to the process of successful delivery (see Chapter 9) – it can enable you to achieve great outcomes. When done badly, with lip service paid to the process and outcomes and with no link to delivery, it is likely to cause you more sleepless nights than you might wish. Strategy and planning really do matter.

Notes

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